

I Couldn't Stop Her

She let another man take
her while I watched



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The lamp in the corner of the living room was the only light still on. Andre had angled the shade so it threw more shadow than glow, which was either considerate or deliberate.

I sat on the couch with what remained of my beer watching the two of them, my girlfriend Tara and this “old friend” of hers, Andre, on the big old chair.

Everyone else had gone by then, Connor and Kim around midnight, Connor with that apologetic half-shrug he does when Kim gives him the look. Then Dani and Jules went, then the group from Andre's work whose names I'd already forgotten. The Uber notifications pinged one by one like a slow countdown, so that it was just the three of us. The playlist Andre had switched to, something slower, lower, was the kind of music that fills a room with not much more than a heavy beat. It was too loud to comfortably talk.

Tara was sitting on Andre's lap. She'd ended up there that way things end up at the tail end of a good night, gradually, innocently, and without a moment where you could point and say *there, that's when it happened*.

I'd been in the kitchen getting another drink and when I came back, she was there, sideways across his thighs with her legs draped over the arm of the chair, her head tipped back laughing at something he'd said. His hand was resting on her knee like it was nothing. He was holding her there as though he had grabbed her in passing, but she wasn't resisting much anymore, she was sinking into him, giving up the fight.

I sat down on the couch. Nobody said anything about it to me.

That was the thing I keep circling back to. Nobody said anything because apparently there was nothing to say, or because saying something would make it a thing, and right now it was still hovering in that ambiguous space where it could be nothing. Tara and I knew each other going on three years. People sat on each other's laps, it happened with old good friends. It was

late at night, we were all loose, and the lamp was doing its shading thing in the corner. It was his place, we were chilling after a big party.

I took a sip of my beer and watched Andre say something low near Tara's ear. Tara laughed again, but quieter this time, and she kicked her feet up like it was something bad he'd said. She gave him the evil eye, but with a pursed grin and her cheeks blushing.

I stayed relaxed. I remained very focused on keeping myself like that. What do you do in a situation like that? I didn't want to be that guy.

Andre said something else and Tara turned her head to look at him with deeper shock. The angle put her face too close to his, but she didn't move back.

"You're such an idiot," she said with mock seriousness, shaking her head.

"You know it, baby," Andre said.

She narrowed her eyes at him but she was smiling at him, too, grinning really. Her hand came up to his forearm now, not in a grip, but more like it landed there and she hadn't thought a thing about it. Andre's thumb moved on her knee, a small movement like he didn't even know he was doing it. They'd been friends a long time, she told me, "back in the, you know."

I peeled the label off my beer bottle in strips and made a small pile of them on the cushion beside me.

"Bryce," Andre said.

I looked up.

"You want another?"

I looked at the bottle in my hand still a third full.

"I'm good," I said.

He nodded and looked back at Tara. She was saying something to him now I hadn't caught the start of, and he was listening with his chin raised the way one does when they're making a show of really listening.

"...I told her that," Tara said. "I told her exactly that, but she didn't want to hear it."

"She never does," Andre said.

"No." Tara exhaled. "Never."

It was a private conversation. A song ended and another started, slower than the last one. Andre reached for the side table without disturbing her and turned the volume up a notch. The bass took over the room like something physical.

I finished the last third of my beer in one go and set the bottle down on the floor. It was time to go.

Tara's shoe had come half off. It dangled from her toes, a white canvas sneaker, swinging.

I thought about saying I was thinking it was time to head out, but I didn't say anything.

Andre shifted in the chair and Tara adjusted with him, the two of them moving together like water finding its level. She ended up more relaxed with her shoulder against his chest. His arm went along the back of the chair behind her, not around her, but along the back.

"I'm tired," Tara said privately into his ear, a grin on her face, also private, turned away from me.

"So go to sleep," Andre said.

"Can't sleep sitting up."

"I've seen you sleep in worse positions."

She laughed unguarded. "When have you ever seen that?" She lightly tapped his face.

"Minden Street. New Year's."

"That was different, I was..." She stopped and glanced at me a split second. "That was different," she said very quietly into his ear.

"How so?" he grinned, teasing her.

"It just was, and you know it," she said more quietly to him in a kind of warning tone not to go there.

Andre grinned with a slow smile. "Okay, baby," he said.

I stood up and went to the kitchen and I ran the cold tap and put my hands under and dried them on my jeans. The kitchen window faced the street and the street was empty, just orange light on wet pavement. It had been raining which I hadn't noticed.

I opened the fridge but I wasn't hungry. I stood there with the door open looking at the shelves, a block of cheese in cling wrap, some kind of takeaway container, four beers in a row.

I took one and opened it on the edge of the counter with the heel of my hand, a short, sharp movement. The cap skittered across the tiles.

When I came back they'd moved again. Tara now turned so that she was facing more forward, both of them facing the middle of the room sort of side by side in the chair, and Andre's hand had moved from the back of the chair to her shoulder, hanging on the round of it.

Tara watched me come back in. "Hey," she said, as though maybe I'd left.

"Hey," I said. I sat back down on the couch.

"You hiding in the kitchen now?" she said.

"Getting a drink."

She looked at the beer in my hand and then back at me. Something moved through her expression quickly.

"You good?" she said.

"Yeah," I said. "I'm good."

Andre was looking at the middle distance. He picked up his drink from the side table and swallowed some of it and then tipped at her lips.

She closed her hands around his and tilted back to drink his drink. His hand went back to her shoulder.

"We should probably..." Tara started to say to him.

"It's not even two," Andre said.

"I know, but..." Her eyes flashed over to me.

"So stay," he said. It wasn't a demand, it was softer than that, a suggestion.

Tara looked at me and I looked back at her. I kept my expression open and easy, I didn't want to give her anything to work with because I didn't know what I had to give.

She looked back at Andre.

"Okay, I guess one more," she said.

Andre nodded once and he stood up. She slid off his lap and landed on her feet in that smooth automatic way, and he went to the kitchen. The moment he was gone the room felt different. Tara remained standing and picked up her shoe from where it had fallen and held it in her hand looking at me across the room.

"What?" she said.

"Nothing," I said.

"You've got a face on."

"I don't have a face on."

She held my eyes for a second longer then she looked away and dropped back down into the chair, her bare foot tucked up under her. She was holding onto both her shoes like she was considering putting them on, maybe thinking about getting ready to go.

The fridge opened in the kitchen and Andre said something to himself, too quiet to hear.

He came back with two beers held in one hand and set them on the table.

He didn't sit back in the chair. He sat on the arm of it, above where Tara was sitting, and reached down and took the shoes out of her hands and dropped them back on the floor. She watched him do it and he cracked his own beer and looked at me.

"So," he said.

"So," I said.

"Good party?"

"Yeah," I said. "A great party."

Tara was looking at the shoes on the floor. Andre's knee was six inches from her face. She reached up without looking and took one of the beers from the table and drank it.

"You remember Minden Street," Andre said. It wasn't a question.

"We were talking about that," Tara said, as though to jog me.

"Best night ever."

"It was a good night," she said.

"Bryce threw up in a planter," Andre said.

"I didn't throw up," I said. "I dry heaved."

Tara laughed, sharply, and pressed her lips together. Andre looked down at her when she laughed.

I took a long pull of my beer.

The playlist slipped seamlessly into something with even a lower repetitive bass-line, no real melody at all, the kind of track that's designed to do something to a room rather than be listened to. Andre had built this playlist and it had been building toward something all night which I was only now understanding.

"I'm gonna use the bathroom," I said.

I got up and went down the hall. The bathroom was at the end, past Andre's bedroom with the door half open and the bed visible, unmade, the duvet pushed back. I went in the bathroom and closed the door and ran the tap and looked at myself in the mirror.

My jaw was tight. I made myself unclench it.

I ran cold water and pressed both hands flat against the basin and leaned on it and breathed. The extractor fan hummed. A taxi went past outside, the headlight glare crossing the glass of the window.

I dried my face and went back down the hall, but I stopped in the archway.

Tara was standing now in front of the chair and Andre was still on the arm of it. They were talking quietly, faces close, and his hand was on her waist under the hem of her jacket. I could see from where I was standing that his fingers were against her bare skin above her jeans.

Neither of them had heard me come back.

I stood there for three full seconds, then I walked back into the room. My foot caught the edge of the coffee table and the bottles on it shifted and clattered and Tara stepped back from Andre in one clean movement and looked over at me.

"Sorry," I said. "Table."

Her short jacket hem fell normally but she tugged it down anyway.

Andre looked at me with an expression that was completely calm and completely unreadable and he took a drink of his beer.

I sat down on the couch. Tara picked up her beer from the table. She didn't sit back in the chair but stayed standing, one arm across her stomach, the hand with the beer, her weight on one foot.

"I got to find my other shoe," she said with a grin.

"You're holding it," Andre said.

She looked down at her hand. "Right," she said, and she laughed with shyness and looked down and away.

She put her beer down and sat on the floor to put both shoes on, doing her laces in two sharp movements. I looked at Andre but he was watching her.

I said, "Tara."

She looked up from her laces.

"Come sit over here," I said.

Something crossed her face quickly but she smoothed it out. She got up off the floor and came to the couch to sit down next to me, close, her thigh against mine. I put my hand on her knee and felt her leg tense under my hand and then release. She stared now at Andre, sitting beside me.

Andre got up from the arm of the chair and stretched, his arms going up, his shirt lifting, and he rolled his neck once and picked up his beer.

"Music's too quiet," he said, and went to his phone on the side table.

He turned it up more so the bass filled the room. He moved around the table and sat down on the couch on the other side of Tara.

The three of us sat there, Tara in the middle, and the music pressed in from all sides. Tara remained still. She had her beer in both hands on her lap.

and she was looking straight ahead at the blank television screen. Our reflections sat in the dark glass of it, grey and warped. Andre put his arm along the back of the couch behind her.

I thought about the first time I'd met him, four years ago probably, a Sunday afternoon in someone else's kitchen, and how I'd thought immediately that I didn't trust him, this easy unhurried guy with the slow smile. I thought about how I still didn't like him.

Tara's thumb moved back and forth across the neck of her bottle. Andre's arm remained along the back of the couch so his hand was behind Tara's shoulder. His fingers moved against the back of her neck, slowly, like he was brushing something away. Tara's chin dropped a fraction. Her eyes went to her lap.

"This track," Andre said.

"Mm?" Tara said.

"You know this one?"

"No, I don't think so."

"I'll send it to you."

Her thumb remained moving on the bottle neck and she nodded once, small, and took a drink.

Andre's fingers went from the back of her neck and into her hair, the tips of them at the base of her skull. He did it the way you do something you've done a thousand times, with no hesitation, no notice, Tara's head tilting back by half an inch.

I put my beer on the table and looked at Andre across Tara. His hand was in her hair, pulling, twisting, but he was looking at me with that same open and easy expression, the one that gave nothing away, the one that had always made him so good at cards.

Tara was looking at something in the middle distance, unfocused, like a person listening to something far away. Her shoulder was against mine and I could feel her breathing slow and relaxed, the way people breathe when they're very conscious of their breathing.

Andre's fingers moved in her hair deeper, a slow combing motion, working from the base of her neck upward. Tara's eyes closed for a second and then half opened.

The room felt pressurized. It felt like the inside of something sealed.

I should have said something at the shoe moment, or in the doorway. Each had been a chance to speak and I had not taken any of them and now

they were behind me, banked up, and I was here on this couch with the bass going hard and Andre's hand moving in my girlfriend's hair in full view of me and everyone behaving as though this was just the expected end of a party night between three friends.

I cleared my throat. Tara shifted. The shift moved her hair through Andre's fingers and he let his hand come to rest on her shoulder, the far one away from me. His arm was around her now. The geometry had changed while I'd been thinking about what to say.

"Remember that night at Kim's," Tara suddenly said. I thought at first she was talking to me. Her voice was different, lower and slower than usual, like something had been turned down in her.

"Which one?" Andre said.

"The one where Connor got into it with that guy from her work."

"Jamie."

"Was that his name?"

"Yeah," Andre said. "Jamie. Forklift guy."

"He was so angry," Tara said, biting her lip.

"Connor or Jamie."

She almost laughed. "Both. Both of them."

I said, "I remember that."

They both looked at me like they'd forgotten I was there. I had the sudden sensation that I'd spoken from further away than I was.

"Yeah," I said. "They went outside with it."

"They did," Andre said.

"Nothing happened though," Tara said.

"Nothing happened, no," Andre agreed.

The conversation closed back over like water. I was on the outside of the surface of it, looking down through it at the shapes below.

Andre turned his head toward Tara, a partial turn, his jaw near her temple, and I watched him say something that I didn't hear, the music was too loud. Tara's lips pressed together and she looked down at her hands and the corner of her mouth curled.

I stood up. Both of them looked up at me.

I walked to the window. The street was still empty, the pavement still wet. A fox was sitting on the opposite side under the orange light, absolutely still, looking at something I couldn't see. I watched it turned its

head and look directly at the window and then walk away unhurried into the dark between two parked cars.

I had my hand in my pocket. My phone was in my hand and I fiddled with it. Behind me the couch made a small sound but I didn't turn around.

I could see the room in the black glass of the window, washed out and smeared, the lamp in the corner throwing its light, the shape of the two of them on the couch blurred and without detail. Just shapes. I couldn't see exactly what the shapes were doing but I watched them anyway.

Andre's shape moved toward Tara's shape in a way I couldn't interpret precisely in the reflection. Her shape didn't move away.

My hand went tight around my phone.

The rain had started again, light and directionless, hazing the orange light into something soft and sourceless, and the wet pavement held the whole street upside down and wrong, the way reflections are.

I turned around. Andre was kissing my girlfriend Tara's neck.

He was doing it slowly, his mouth against the place where her neck met her shoulder, and Tara was sitting with her head turned away from him and her eyes open and her beer still in both hands on her lap. She was looking at the floor, tilting her head for him. .

She didn't stop him.

I walked back to the couch and sat down. The cushion depressed under me and Tara's eyes came up from the floor and found my face and stayed there. Her expression was open in a way that was almost unbearable, not with guilt exactly, not defiant, either, just open, like a door that had been left that way.

Andre didn't stop. His mouth moved up her neck, unhurried, and his hand came from her shoulder to her jaw, not gripping exactly, just resting against it, his thumb below her ear.

Tara's eyes remained on mine and I looked back at her. The music went on pressing into every corner of the room.

I said, "Tara."

"Yeah?" she said. Her voice was completely level.

I didn't say anything after that. I put her name there and she answered it and now we were here, the three of us in this configuration, and I had no idea what was going on. Nothing in me had a word for what was happening.

Andre raised his head from her neck and he looked at me over her shoulder. His expression was the same as it had been all night, that same

unhurried openness, and he held my eyes for a moment and then looked at Tara.

“Yeah?” he said to her.

She didn't look at him, she was still looking at me.

“Yeah,” she said to him, not taking her eyes from mine.

Andre's hand moved from her jaw down the front of her throat, slowly, and came to rest flat against her sternum. I could see it rising and falling with her breathing, which was not slow anymore.

My hands were on my own knees and I looked down at them. They looked like someone else's hands, pale and still, the knuckles gone white.

I picked up my beer and drank from it. When I put it down Andre moved.

He was turning toward her fully now, one knee up on the couch, and his hand was at the hem of her jacket, working it back from her shoulder.

Tara let it go. The jacket slid off her arm and he reached across and pulled it from the other side and dropped it behind the couch. She sat there in just her top and jeans.

Tara finally looked away from me. She looked down at Andre's hand now on her stomach.

He had his palm flat against her stomach over the top, and he spread his fingers slowly. Her breath came out in a way that was not a sigh and not a gasp.

I sat forward, elbows on my knees, and watched my hands knit together in the space between them. The pressure in the room had changed. It wasn't uncomfortable exactly, that was the strange part. It had crossed some threshold and come out the other side as something else entirely.

Andre's hand moved higher, slowly, until his fingers reached the bottom edge of Tara's ribs. She drew in a breath that I heard clearly even through the music. The sound of it was conscious, deliberate, like she was reminding herself that breathing was something she had to do, however sharply and uneven.

I looked up. Tara's eyes found mine immediately, like she'd been waiting for me to look. There was a question in them, deeper, more complicated, something about whether I was going to stay or leave, whether I was going to say or do anything.

I remained in place. I leaned back against the couch and picked up my beer. The glass was warm now, the condensation long evaporated. I drank it.

Andre's other hand came up now and pushed Tara's hair back from her face, tucking it behind her ear with a gentleness that I recognized. I'd seen him do careful things before, handle drunk Connor, talk down an argument, fix something broken with that same steady attention. The recognition of it did something to me, lodged somewhere in my chest.

Tara's eyes stayed on mine for another moment, that question still in them, and then Andre's hand moved further up and she turned her head toward him.

Just like that, I wasn't part of it anymore. Not excluded, exactly. But separate.

Andre leaned in and Tara's face tilted up to him and he kissed her.

The kiss was slow, like one wave following another. Tara's hand came up to his face, her fingers spreading around his jaw, and she made a soft sound against his mouth that I felt more than heard.

I should have looked away. But I sat there with the warm beer in my hand and watched my girlfriend kiss this guy on the couch eighteen inches away from me, and I didn't move, I didn't speak.

The kiss deepened. Andre's hand went to her waist and he pulled her closer. Tara went, turning more fully toward him, her knee coming up onto the couch between them. Her other hand found his chest, fingers spreading against his shirt, and I could see her grip it, a convulsive motion, like she was needed to hold onto something.

They broke apart for air. Tara's eyes remained closed. Andre's forehead rested against hers and they stayed like that, breathing together. I watched Tara's face in the dim light, a slight parting of her lips, the flutter of her eyelashes, a flush spreading down her neck.

Andre's hand moved from her waist to her ribs. He didn't pull her top up. He slid his hand underneath, his fingers disappearing beneath the fabric, and Tara's breath caught audibly. Her eyes opened halfway, unfocused, looking at nothing. Then they closed again.

His hand moved higher under her shirt. I could track its progress by the way the fabric stretched, by the way Tara's breathing changed, got shallower, faster. She was still gripping his shirt with one hand. The other hand dropped to his thigh.

I was invisible to them. I could have stood up and walked out and I don't think either of them would have noticed. The realization sat in me strange and heavy, not painful, more like displacement, like I'd become a ghost.

Andre kissed her again, harder this time, and Tara made that sound again, a desperate small sound, and her hand on his thigh gripped tighter. His hand under her shirt reached higher. Tara's whole body reacted, arching into him, a shudder running through her that I could see even from where I sat.

Andre's mouth moved to her neck. Tara's head fell back to give him access. Her eyes fell closed and her mouth hung open. She looked like someone drowning in warmth. Andre's hand moved higher under her shirt, a slow smooth motion, and Tara gasped and her hand flew up to grip his shoulder.

I took another drink of my beer. The music kept playing, the lamp kept glowing, and outside the rain kept falling on the empty street. On the couch beside me my girlfriend let the man touch her in ways I couldn't understand, and I sat there and watched her face transform with it.

Andre pulled her shirt up so that it bunched under her arms exposing her stomach and bra, black fabric against pale skin. Tara didn't stop him. She lifted her arms to allow him and then they were down again, gripping his shoulders, and Andre's mouth was on her collarbone and his hands were on her bare skin.

I could see everything, the way his fingers spread against her ribs, the way her stomach contracted when he touched it, the small mole she had just below her sternum that I'd kissed a hundred times.

Tara's hand went to the back of Andre's neck and held him there against her collarbone. She turned her head, and for just a moment her eyes opened and she looked directly at me.

She saw me, though her vision was glazed over. I knew she saw me because her breath caught and her eyes went wide a moment, something like recognition moving across them. But she didn't pull away and she didn't stop Andre's hands. She just looked at me with those wide dark and blank eyes while he kissed her throat, and I looked back at her, and then her eyes fluttered closed again and I became invisible once more.

The moment lasted maybe three seconds.

Andre shifted, moving closer, and Tara moved with him, their bodies finding a new configuration. His hand slid up her back to the clasp of her bra. I heard the small snap of it opening. Tara's breathing stopped a moment, then started again, faster.

The bra loosened from her body. Andre's hands moved around to the front and Tara made a sound, a whimper, and pressed herself against him as

though to hide herself.

I set my beer down on the floor beside the couch.

The sound of glass on wood was very quiet and neither of them heard it, neither of them turned. Andre's hands were moving under the loosened fabric and Tara's back was arched and her fingers were in his hair. I was close enough to touch them.

The playlist shifted to something even slower and deeper. Andre pulled back just enough to look at Tara's face and she opened her eyes and looked back at him. Something passed between them that was private, that belonged only to them, and then he kissed her again and she melted into it this time.

His hands slid the bra straps down her shoulders and Tara let him. She pulled her arms from the straps one at a time and the whole thing came away. Andre dropped it somewhere behind the couch where her jacket had gone, and now she was bare from the waist up in the dim light.

I had seen her like this a thousand times, but not like this, not with a man's hands on her, not with that expression on her face, that complete surrender to sensation, that openness.

Andre's mouth moved lower, down from her collarbone, and Tara's head fell back against the couch. Her hand gripped his hair and the sound she made was raw and unguarded and it filled the room.

I sat there and watched and didn't speak or move and the rain kept falling and the music kept playing as my girlfriend came completely undone under someone else's hands three feet away from me. I was a witness to it, a ghost in the corner of a room where something was happening that had its own momentum now, its own gravity, something that would continue whether I was there or not.

Tara's hand reached down between them. I saw it move to the button of Andre's jeans. That was when I looked away.

Some part of me understood that past this point I would be seeing something I could never unsee, and I needed a second before I crossed that line.

I looked at a water stain on the ceiling, a pale brown ring near the light fitting. Behind me, I heard the sound of a zipper, fabric moving, Tara's breathing getting faster, Andre's breath getting rougher.

I looked back. Tara had moved onto Andre's lap. I didn't see the transition, I had looked away for maybe ten seconds and when I looked

back she was straddling him, her knees on either side of his thighs, her bare skin against his chest. His shirt was still on but her hands were under it, pushing it up, and he lifted his arms and let her pull it over his head.

She dropped it on the floor. For a moment they just stayed like that, looking at each other, Tara's hands flat against Andre's chest and his at her waist, thumbs moving in slow circles against her bare skin. Her breathing was audible even over the music, quick shallow pulls of air like she was cold, but she wasn't.

Andre's hands slid up her sides, slowly. His palms dragged against her skin, up over her ribs, and Tara's eyes closed and her mouth fell open and her whole body shivered. His hands kept moving up until they reached her breasts, and when he touched her there Tara made a sound that was almost a sob.

Her hips moved, a small roll forward against him. Andre's jaw clenched and his hands tightened on her and she did it again, harder this time, and I could see the exact moment the last thread of restraint between them snapped.

Andre pulled her down into a kiss that was nothing like the earlier ones. It was hungry, desperate. His hand went to the back of her head and held her there hard and Tara kissed him back with the same intensity, her fingers digging into his shoulders hard enough that I could see the skin go white under her nails.

Her hips kept moving on his, grinding him into the couch, grinding against him in a slow rhythm that matched the bass line of the song. Andre's other hand dropped to her hip, guiding her, encouraging her, and Tara's head fell back and she gasped at the ceiling.

I could see the line of her throat, the flush spreading down from her face across her chest, the way her stomach muscles contracted with each movement. She was still wearing her jeans but I could see the outline of Andre beneath the denim, could see exactly what she was grinding against, and my brain supplied information I didn't want about how it must feel for her, how thin denim was, how much pressure, how much friction.

Andre's mouth went to her neck. He kissed down the column of it, open-mouthed, and when he reached her collarbone he bit down gently and Tara cried out, her back arching, pushing her chest toward him. He took the invitation and his mouth moved lower, across the top of her breast, and then

lower still, and when his lips closed around her nipple Tara's hand flew to his hair and gripped it so hard I thought it must hurt.

But he didn't stop. His tongue moved against her and Tara made a continuous sound now, a low whimper that didn't stop, in and out, it just kept going as her hips moved faster against him, forward and back. His hand came up to her other breast, fingers working, and I watched her come apart piece by piece under the dual sensation.

She was saying something I couldn't make it out at first, her voice was too rough, too broken. But then I caught it.

"Please," she was saying. "Please, please, please."

Andre's hand left her breast and went to the button of her jeans.

He flicked it open one-handed, the movement practiced and sure, and Tara lifted herself up on her knees just enough for him to get the zipper down. The sound of it was loud in the room.

Andre's hand slid inside. I saw it disappear beneath the denim and Tara went absolutely rigid for one long moment, every muscle locked, and then she shattered. Her whole body convulsed and her mouth opened in a silent scream. Her hands gripped Andre's shoulders like they were the only thing keeping her from flying apart.

He hadn't even taken her jeans off. His hand moved under the fabric in ways I couldn't see, and Tara was falling apart on top of him, her hips jerking in sharp erratic motions, her head thrown back, her throat working around sounds that didn't quite make it out.

I couldn't breathe. I was trying to inhale but my chest wouldn't expand. My hands were gripping my own thighs hard enough to hurt and I couldn't let go.

Andre's other hand came up to Tara's face. He turned her head down toward him, made her look at him, and I saw his mouth move but couldn't hear what he said. Whatever it was, Tara nodded frantically, desperately, and Andre's hand moved faster under her jeans. She broke again, worse this time, or better this time, her whole body shaking with it.

When she came down she collapsed against him.

Her face buried in his neck, her chest heaving against his, both of them breathing like they'd been running. Andre's hand slid out of her jeans and came to rest on her lower back, holding her against him. His other hand stroked her hair with a tenderness that made something crack open wider in my chest.

They stayed like that for a long moment, just breathing, just holding each other. The song changed and Tara's shoulders shook. I couldn't tell if she was laughing or crying or both.

Then she pushed herself upright. Her hands went to Andre's jeans again.

She got the button open, got the zipper down, and Andre lifted his hips for her to push the denim down his thighs and then further, awkwardly half-falling off his lap to get them past his knees, and he kicked them off the rest of the way.

He was in boxer briefs, dark grey. The fabric was tenting and I could see the outline of him clearly. My brain shorted out trying not to process that information and failing completely.

Tara climbed back onto his lap. She settled her weight on him fully now, nothing between them but two thin layers of fabric, and they both made sounds at the contact. Andre's head fell back against the couch and Tara's hands braced on his shoulders and she started moving on him again.

It was slower this time, dragging herself against the length of him with focused intent, and I could see everything, the flex of her thighs, the roll of her hips, the way her breasts against his bare chest moved with each motion. Andre's hands were on her waist, not guiding anymore, just holding on, and his face was doing something I'd never seen it do, all that careful control finally breaking.

"Tara," he said.

His voice was wrecked.

She leaned down and kissed him, still moving. The kiss was deep and messy and graceless. Andre's hands slid down from her waist to her ass, gripping her through the denim, pulling her harder against him, and Tara moaned into his mouth.

Then she pulled back and stood up. Andre's hands fell away and he looked up at her, his chest heaving. Tara looked down at him for one long moment, then her hands went to her jeans.

She pushed them down over her hips, down her thighs, and she had to sit on the edge of the couch to get them past her knees and off her feet, and then she was in just her underwear, black cotton, matching the bra that was somewhere behind the couch, and she stood there for a moment like she was thinking something.

Andre's eyes moved over her body slowly, taking her in.

Then Tara hooked her thumbs in the waistband of her underwear. She paused there, one second, two. But then she pushed them down and stepped out of them and now she was naked in Andre's living room, in the dim light from the corner, three feet away from where I sat frozen in my chair watching this scene unfold like some pornographic horror movie.

I had seen her naked a thousand times of course, but not like this, not standing like this in a living room, offering herself like this, and not to someone else.

Andre reached for her. She came back to him, climbing onto his lap again, and this time, when she settled down against him, there was nothing between them but his boxer briefs. I watched his whole body go rigid with the feel of her.

His hands roamed everywhere over her body, down her back, over the curve of her ass, up her sides to her breasts, learning her, mapping her. Tara was making continuous small sounds now with each breath in and out, little gasps and whimpers, and her hands were in his hair and on his face and over his shoulders, equally desperate to touch him everywhere at once.

She reached down between them and her hand slid inside his boxer briefs. Andre made a sound between a groan and a growl, and Tara's hand moved. His hips jerked up involuntarily under her and she smirked.

Then she was pushing his boxer briefs down. He lifted his hips and she got them past his thighs and he kicked them off and now they were both naked, both completely bared to each other. Tara positioned herself over him and paused there, just at the edge of it, and I could see her hand between them, guiding him, positioning herself.

And my girlfriend sank down slowly.

Her mouth fell open wide, her eyes went unfocused. Andre's hands gripped her hips hard enough to leave marks and his jaw clenched. They both made sounds that weren't words as she took him in inch by inch inside her until she was fully seated in his lap.

For a moment neither of them moved. They sat there, joined, breathing, and I sat in the chair and watched them. I felt something fundamental in the architecture of my life shift and resettle into a new shape.

Then Tara started to move. She rolled her hips slowly at first, rising up until he almost slipped out of her, then sinking back down with agonizing care. Her thighs flexed with each movement and Andre's fingers dug deeper

into her hips. His breathing came in harsh pulls through his teeth as though in pain.

Tara's hands were braced on his shoulders, using them for leverage, and her head hung forward so her hair fell around her face. I could see her expression through the curtain of it, eyes closed, mouth open, completely lost.

Andre pulled her down into a kiss. She whimpered against his mouth and her rhythm faltered, became unsteady, and Andre's hands moved from her hips to her ass. He gripped her there and started moving her himself, faster now, harder, lifting her and pulling her down onto him in a building rhythm that made her break the kiss to cry at the ceiling.

The couch creaked beneath them. A rhythmic sound matched their movement, leather and springs protesting. Tara's gasps got louder, less controlled, until she wasn't even trying to be quiet anymore. She was crying out, raw and shameless, and Andre watched her face like he was memorizing it.

His hand came up between them. It moved to where they were joined and his thumb found her there. Tara's whole body jolted like she'd been shocked. Her rhythm broke completely. She tried to keep moving but couldn't coordinate it anymore, couldn't focus through whatever his thumb was doing to her, and she ended up just grinding down against him in tight desperate, whimpering circles.

"Don't stop," she managed. "Don't, fuck! don't stop."

Those were her first actual words in minutes and they hung in the air. Andre didn't stop. His thumb kept moving and his other hand gripped her ass harder and Tara's movements got more erratic, more desperate, like she was chasing something.

She went quiet and still, seized up entirely, and then screamed loud and high, her whole body going rigid again and then shaking violently. Andre held her through it, his thumb still moving on her, drawing her out, and Tara sobbed his name into the tiny space between them.

She collapsed forward onto his chest. Her body was still trembling, aftershocks running through her. Andre wrapped both arms around her back and he held her close and murmured something against her hair that I couldn't hear.

They stayed like that for maybe thirty seconds. Then Andre shifted. He stood up with Tara still wrapped around him, still inside her, and she made a

surprised sound and locked her legs around his waist. He turned and laid her down on the couch, on her back, and moved on top of her.

He was between her legs now, pressing down against her, and when he pushed back into her they both groaned. Tara's legs came up around his hips and her hands gripped his back and Andre started moving on her.

No longer was it the slow exploration from before. This was something else now, this was need. His hips drove into her with force and Tara's back arched up off the couch and her hands scrabbled for purchase on his shoulders, his back, the fabric of the couch, anywhere.

I could see her face over his shoulder. Her eyes were rolled back, unfocused, and her mouth hung open and sounds were coming out of it with each thrust, sharp little cries that got louder as he moved faster and harder into her.

Andre's rhythm was relentless. He penetrated my girlfriend deep and hard, and the couch was moving with them now, shifting across the floor in small scraping increments. Tara's hands finally found purchase in his hair and she pulled hard and Andre made a sound low in his throat and somehow went harder into her.

Tara's leg slipped off his hip. Her foot hit the floor and gave her leverage. She pushed up to meet him and the angle changed and she cried out, and her hands moved to his ass, pulling him deeper into her.

"There," she gasped. "Right there, right, oh god..."

Andre hooked his arm under her knee and pushed her legs up toward her chest, opening her wider, and when he thrust into her again Tara screamed, both hands flying up to grip the arm of the couch above her head.

I could see everything from where I sat. Every flex of Andre's back muscles, every tremor that ran through Tara's body, the sheen of sweat on both of them. I could see the place where they were joined, visible every time Andre pulled back, slick and obscene, her folds desperately suckling on his length, not letting him out.

Tara was saying something, a chant, almost. "Yes, yes, yes, yes!" in time with his movements, getting higher and more desperate with each repetition.

Andre's other hand moved between them again and he found that place. Tara's chant broke into incoherent sounds and her leg locked tighter around him. Her whole body started shaking.

She came again, harder this time, longer, her back arching so far off the couch I thought something might break in her. She was crying now, actual tears streaming down her temples into her hair, and Andre fucked her through it without mercy, prolonging it, extending it until Tara was begging.

"Please," she sobbed. "Please, I can't, Andre please..."

He slowed, easing back to something gentler, letting her come down. Tara went limp beneath him, her chest heaving, her hands falling slack on the couch above her head.

Andre pulled out. Tara made a small protesting sound but Andre was already moving, already turning her over onto her stomach with hands that were firm but careful. Tara went where he put her, boneless and compliant, and ended up on her knees with her chest against the couch cushion and her ass high in the air.

Andre's hand ran down her spine slowly from her neck to the small of her back and then lower, over the curve of her ass, and Tara shivered under his touch. His other hand gripped her hip and he positioned himself behind her and pushed back in.

Tara's hands gripped the cushion. Her face was turned to the side, pressed against the leather, and I could see her expression clearly now, her eyes squeezed shut, her mouth open, her face flushed and tear-stained and completely undone.

Andre moved in her with a different rhythm now, slower but deeper, each thrust controlled, and I could see the impact travel through Tara's whole body, could see her ass shudder against his hips, could see her fingers go white where she gripped the cushion.

His hand came down on her ass, a slap, more sound than force, and Tara's eyes flew open. She made a shocked sound that turned into a moan. Andre did it again on her other cheek, and Tara pushed back against him, meeting his thrusts, and wanting more.

He gave her more. His rhythm increased and his hand came down again and again, punctuating each thrust. Tara was making continuous sounds now, muffled against the cushion, broken and desperate and begging for something she couldn't articulate.

Andre leaned forward. His chest pressed against her back, pinning her down, and his hand came around to her throat, holding her, and he said something directly into her ear that I couldn't hear.

Whatever it was, Tara nodded frantically, biting her lip.

Andre's hand tightened on her throat and he started moving faster, harder. Tara was pinned beneath him completely now, unable to move, just taking it, and the sounds coming out of her were getting higher, more desperate.

She was going to come again, I could see it building in her, could see the tension gathering in her whole body. Andre could see it too because his hand moved from her throat back down between her legs and the moment he touched her there Tara detonated.

She screamed into the cushion. Her whole body convulsed and Andre held her through it, still moving, still fucking her, and Tara shook apart beneath him in waves that seemed like they would never end.

When it finally released her she went completely limp. Andre pulled out carefully and Tara made a small sound of loss and turned over onto her back on the couch, one arm flung over her eyes, her chest heaving, her thighs trembling.

Andre stood there looking down at her. His chest was heaving too. He was still hard, still slick from being inside her, and Tara's arm moved from her eyes so she saw him standing there and something passed across her face.

She reached for him. Her hand wrapped around him and Andre's breath hissed out between his teeth Tara pulled him closer, pulled him down, and took him into her mouth.

Andre's hands drove into her hair and his head fell back. The sound he made was pure relief. Tara's hand moved in coordination with her mouth, working him, and I could see her cheeks hollow with suction, could see the way Andre's thighs trembled, could see his fingers tighten in her hair.

She took him deeper. Andre made a choked sound and his hips jerked forward involuntarily and Tara took it, and when she pulled back there were tears in her eyes but she went right back down.

"Tara," Andre managed. His voice was wrecked. "I'm, if you don't stop I'm..."

She didn't stop. Her hand moved faster and she took him as deep as she could. Andre's whole body went rigid and he tried to pull back, tried to give her an out, but Tara's other hand gripped his hip and held him there, and when he came she kept him inside her mouth, swallowing him, taking everything he gave her.

Andre's knees buckled. He caught himself on the back of the couch, breathing like he'd been drowning, and Tara let him slip from her mouth

gently and wiped her lips with the back of her hand.

For a moment neither of them moved. Then Andre sank down onto the couch beside her, his back against the cushions, his head tipped back, eyes closed. Tara turned onto her side and curled against him, her head on his chest. Andre's arm came around her, holding her close.

They lay there breathing. The music was still playing. The rain had stopped outside at some point.

I sat rigid in my chair and looked at their naked, sweating, wasted bodies tangled together on the couch and felt nothing and everything simultaneously, like my nervous system had overloaded and shut down and was just feeding me random static.

Tara's eyes opened. She looked directly at me but didn't say anything.

She just looked at me with eyes that were dark and unreadable and exhausted, and then she looked away and sat up slowly. Her movements were careful, like someone testing to see if their body still worked. She picked her panties up from where they had fallen beside the couch and stepped into them.

Andre's eyes remained closed. His chest was still rising and falling heavily. Tara looked down at him for a moment, then reached down and took his hand.

He opened his eyes. She pulled gently and he sat up, then stood, and she led him across the room toward the hallway. Neither of them looked at me. Andre's boxers were still on the floor and he left them there. They walked down the hall naked, Tara in just her panties, Andre in nothing at all, and I heard the bedroom door close, a quiet click of the latch.

I sat there in the living room alone. The couch looked like a disaster, cushions displaced, the leather dark with sweat in places. Tara's jeans were on the floor. Her bra was somewhere behind the couch. Andre's clothes were scattered. My beer was on the floor beside my chair, forgotten, undrinkable.

I thought about leaving. I thought about standing up and walking to the door and going down the stairs and out into the street where it had stopped raining and just walking until I was somewhere else.

But I didn't move. I couldn't.

The music was still playing. Whatever playlist Andre had built, it was still going, track after track of low bass and minimal melody, designed to fill a room with feeling rather than sound.

Then I heard them. It started quiet, a creak of bedsprings, the sound of movement. Then Tara's voice, muffled by the bedroom door but clear enough.

"Come here then."

More movement, the bed protesting. Then nothing for a moment, and I sat there in the silence and stared at the dark television screen and my grey reflection in it.

Then came Tara making a soft noise, then another, then a steady rhythm of them, soft at first, and I realized she was making them in time with something else, in time with movement and the groan of bedsprings, and my brain supplied the image, my girlfriend on top of him, he inside her again already, the bed moving beneath them.

The sounds got louder, enough that I couldn't pretend I wasn't hearing them. Tara's voice, breathless, said something I couldn't make out, then clearer: "Harder, baby."

The bed started making more noise. Rhythmic creaking came steady, Tara's sounds matching it, getting louder with it. There were small cries that built on each other, layered, and underneath them Andre's breathing, harsh and audible even through the wall.

I gripped the arms of my chair. The creaking got faster. Tara got louder. She wasn't trying to be quiet anymore, she wasn't muffling herself, and the sounds she was making were raw and shameless, high desperate gasps and moans that went straight through me and lodged deep inside me.

Something hit the wall, the headboard maybe, a rhythmic thump that joined the creaking, and Tara was saying things now, words I could almost make out, broken fragments between moans.

"...yes..." "...fuck..." "...don't stop..."

The thumping got harder and more insistent. The whole wall was shaking with it and Tara's voice rose higher and higher until she was almost screaming. I sat there and listened to my girlfriend get fucked in the next room and did nothing.

She came. I knew the sound of it. I'd heard it before, but never like this. Never this abandoned. She screamed his name, "Andre!" and the bed shook violently and Tara kept screaming, wordless now, and it went on and on until finally it broke into sobs.

The bed stopped moving. For maybe thirty seconds there was just breathing, heavy and ragged from both of them.

Then it started again. It was different rhythm this time, slower, the bed creaking in long intervals, and Tara's sounds were different too, deeper, more guttural, and drawn out. I heard her say something, heard Andre respond, his voice too low to make out the words.

Then Tara laughed, breathless and delighted, and she said something else and the bed shifted and I heard the unmistakable sound of them changing positions, bodies moving, weight redistributing.

The rhythm changed again when it resumed. It came faster than before and harder, the headboard hitting the wall with force now, a steady bang bang bang. Tara matched it with grunts that were almost violent in their intensity.

"Oh god!" "So deep!" "Yes yes yes..."

This went on for minutes. The relentless rhythm of the headboard and Tara's increasingly desperate sounds along with Andre's occasional grunt of effort, left me sitting there to absorb it all, let it pour into me and fill up all the space inside me.

Tara's voice changed pitch and got higher now, more urgent. She was saying something fast, a stream of words I couldn't separate into meaning, and the bed was shaking the whole wall now and pictures were probably rattling in their frames. She was building toward something again.

When she came this time she didn't scream. She made a sound like something breaking, like something coming apart at a fundamental level. It was long and low and it dissolved into crying, but the bed kept moving through it, Andre not stopping and Tara crying and moaning through it all and saying his name over and over.

"Andre, Andre, Andre..."

The bed stopped. I heard Andre's voice, clearer now, closer to the door. "Turn over."

There was movement and the bed creaked. Then came a sharp slap of skin on skin and Tara's yelp that turned into a jolted moan.

The rhythm started again, punishing now, the headboard hitting the wall so hard I thought it might leave holes. Tara wasn't making words anymore, just sounds, animal and raw, and I could hear the impact of Andre's body against hers, could hear the wet sound of it, and my hands were shaking on the arms of the chair.

There were minutes and minutes of relentless rhythm, Tara's voice hoarse now, breaking, and Andre's breathing getting harsher, more ragged. Finally

his rhythm broke, got erratic, and Tara was encouraging him, her voice wrecked but clear.

"Come for me, baby" all breathy, and "want to feel you inside me" and "come inside me baby."

Andre made a sound I'd never heard a human make, guttural and helpless, and the bed shook one final time and Tara groaned to the heavens and the bed went still. There was just breathing again, heavy and desperate, and then silence.

I thought maybe they were done, that maybe they'd exhausted themselves finally. Maybe they'd fall asleep and I could finally stand up and leave this chair and walk out of this apartment and this night.

Then I heard Tara's laugh again, softer this time, and intimate. Andre said something and she said something back and there was more movement, gentler now, and I realized they weren't done at all.

The bed started creaking again, slow and steady, and Tara made a satisfied sound. I sat back in my chair in that living room surrounded by their scattered clothes and listened to them fuck for the second hour straight, and I still did not leave.

I was startled awake. It was past four when the bedroom door opened. I hear the quiet click of the latch, then footsteps in the hallway. Tara appeared in the doorway wearing one of Andre's t-shirts, grey and oversized, hanging to mid-thigh. Her hair was a mess. Her face was flushed and her lips were swollen. There were marks on her neck and thighs.

She looked at me and I raised my eyes back at her.

She walked past me to where her clothes were scattered and started picking them up, her jeans from the floor, her bra from behind the couch. She found her shirt bunched under the coffee table. She collected them methodically and in no hurry, and then she pulled Andre's t-shirt off over her head and stood there naked again for the few seconds it took to put her bra back on.

I watched her dress. She did it efficiently, bra, shirt, jeans. She sat on the arm of the couch to pull her socks and shoes on, doing the laces in those same two sharp movements from hours ago. When she was done she stood up and looked around for her jacket and found it on the floor behind the couch and pulled that on too.

Then she walked over to where I was sitting and she held out her hand.

I looked at it, her hand, palm up, fingers curled, waiting.

"Coming?" she said.

Her voice was hoarse, wrecked from screaming.

I stood up. I didn't take her hand and she let her it drop and turned and walked to the door. I followed her. She opened it quietly and stepped out into the hallway and I stepped out after her and pulled the door closed behind us.

The stairwell was fluorescent bright after the amber dimness of the apartment. Tara went down the stairs ahead of me and I followed at a distance and we went out into the street where the rain had stopped and the pavement was still wet and reflecting the streetlights in long orange smears.

My car was parked two blocks away. We walked to it in silence, our footsteps the only sound, echoing off the closed shopfronts and dark windows. When we reached the car I unlocked it and we both got in.

I started the engine. The dashboard lit up blue-white and the radio started automatically, some late-night station playing something quiet, and I reached forward and turned it off. The silence rushed in to fill the space.

I pulled out onto the empty street. Tara lived fifteen minutes away, left here, straight for six blocks, right at the lights. The streets were completely empty, no cars, no people, just wet pavement and traffic lights cycling through their patterns for no one.

Tara sat in the passenger seat with her hands in her lap and looked out the window at the city going by.

I could smell her, not perfume, not her usual scent, but something else. Sweat and sex and Andre. It filled the car, it was inescapable, and I breathed it in with every breath and said nothing.

We hit a red light. I stopped and we sat there idling. The light refracted a thousands times off the wet windscreen and Tara shifted in her seat. I could see her in my peripheral vision but I didn't turn to look at her.

The light turned green and I drove on, left turn, straight, right at the lights. Her street appeared ahead, the familiar row of terraced houses, lights all off, everyone sleeping. I pulled up outside her building and put the car in neutral and sat there with the engine running staring straight ahead.

Tara unbuckled her seatbelt. She turned toward me and leaned across the center console. I didn't move or pull back. I just sat there and she came closer until her face was inches from mine and I could see every mark on her neck, every place Andre's mouth had been.

She kissed me. Her mouth was soft against mine, gentle, but also used, still hot, smudged and pressed and rubbed. And with the contact came a smell, sharp and unmistakable, on her breath, the scent of it filling my nose and throat. Andre. The taste of him was still in her mouth, from the bedroom, acrid and male and wrong.

I sat perfectly still. Tara's hand came up to my face, holding me there, and she kissed me for three seconds that felt like minutes, and then she pulled back.

She looked at me once more and then opened the car door and got out and walked quickly to her building, almost running, and let herself in and disappeared into the dark hallway beyond without looking back.

I sat in my car with my engine running and the acrid, toxic smell of him still in my nose and mouth.

The street was empty. The windows were all dark. A cat furtively crossed the road, unhurried, and disappeared between two parked cars.

I put the car in gear and drove home. I didn't think, I just drove on autopilot, turning where I was supposed to turn, stopping where I was supposed to stop, until I pulled up outside my own building and turned off the engine.

I got out and went inside and climbed the stairs to my apartment and let myself in and stood in my own living room in the dark.

I walked to the bathroom and turned on the light and looked at myself in the mirror.

I looked the same. I turned on the tap and filled my cupped hands with cold water and brought it to my mouth and rinsed and spat. The smell was still there. I rinsed again and spat but it didn't go away.

I turned off the light and went to bed and lay in the dark with my eyes wide open and waited for morning light.

Of course nothing could ever be the same. But how they were different, I wasn't so sure. Because my cock was hard as a steel rod when I finally lay on my back in my own bed, and my hand was clenched around it tightly, slowly pumping myself so as not to come too quick and forget some of the more delicious details.